

A reflection letter

What I have learned in English 101 has been driven by Bellingham Technical Colleges' College-Level Student Learning Outcomes (CLSLOs) and by English 101s' learning outcomes. I'll just focus on three of them, two from the CLSLOs and one English 101 learning outcome. From the CLSLOs, these are "Critical Thinking: Analyze and critique information and apply decision-making strategies to solve problems," "Cultural Responsiveness: Identify and convey the value of diversity and inclusiveness for the workplace and community." And English 101's learning outcome: "Develop content to support claims in various rhetorical contexts." These are the areas I improved the most in from my time in English 101.

Critically thinking

In this class, there were several discussions that required us to think of questions that showed critical thinking. The simplest way to think of a critical thinking question is to ask yourself, "can it be answered in the resource by a yes or no?" If it can, then it doesn't require critical thinking. For you to have done critical thinking, you must draw your answer or question from multiple sources and perspectives, you must read "between the lines." All a critical question has to do is ask a question that requires the reader to think, to look for an answer outside of the text. English 101 asked me specifically to write critical questions about texts provided in class; and it was the second time I was asked to write these critical questions was when I felt I had a good grasp on how to ask critical questions. That assignment and text was "Reading Discussion: Shitty First Drafts by Anne Lamott" and the critical question I had was: "Is carefully formatting what you're writing from the get-go a valid option? Or are they just under constant stress, but can just miraculously get through it?" This question asks if Lamott's (2005) assertion that for writers with excellent prose and form, "not one of them writes elegant first drafts" and

for the one that does, “we do not like her very much. We do not think that she has a rich inner life or that God likes her or can even stand her” (para. 1). With this example, Lamott made the statement that writers don’t write well on her first try, and it’s rare to find people who can. My question expands beyond the idea that those kinds of people are rare, and asks what makes it possible for them? These critical questions are never easy to find. To discover these questions, I had to re-read the media provided over and over again. And even then, I wasn’t always comfortable with what I had come up with. But these challenges show an ability to “analyze and critique information and apply decision-making strategies to solve problems” as defined in the CLSLSO.

Diversity in communication

Now how have I learned cultural responsiveness, more specifically in writing? When I was looking for a critical question from one of the provided texts in the class, “Should Writers Use They Own English?” by Vershawn Ashanti Young, I had an epiphany: “Do the rigid rules and standards of SAE actually get in the way of people being able to understand it? By trying to be ‘neutral’ is it actually helping no one?” I’ve encountered it many times in Microsoft Word that when I rely too much on the “editor” feature to fix my sentences, my meaning and the personality of my writing is lost. Young’s article taught me that it’s okay if the autocorrect doesn’t like how I write, there is more to readability and conveying a message through writing than conformity to a single way of writing and sounding “proper.” His article criticizes the enforcement of standard English in academic and professional settings, along with proposing the idea of “code meshing” as a superior form of studying communication than “code switching.” He uses a great method of supporting his thesis by instead of hypocritically using standard English, he writes entirely in black English vernacular, or “street talk.” When I first read the article, I

barely even noticed there was something unusual with how it was written, and it didn't hinder my understanding either. It really showed me that the stiff and largely white way of speaking inherent to standard English is not necessary for academic writing to have merit. After my time in English 101, I am more receptive to various ways of speaking and writing that don't fit what I am used to.

Integrating sources and supporting my points

The final learning outcome I want to highlight is English 101 specific. Students who can “develop content to support claims in various rhetorical contexts” can effectively paraphrase and integrate quotes to support their points, which I learned how to do. I'll highlight two examples of quote integration from my work. The first is from my Rhetorical Situation Assignment, where to introduce the ad campaign I rhetorically examined, I paraphrased an article from Adweek which covered the same ad campaign.

“In the November 2006 issue of Macworld magazine, page 31 features a full-page advertisement from Nikon. This ad is part of their Stunningnikon campaign, where Nikon sent two hundred cameras to the residents of Georgetown, South Carolina and used the resulting photos in their marketing material (Lippert, 2007)” (Logan, 2026, p.2).

In this example, I paraphrased a relevant article to introduce a topic. It gives a brief introduction to the ad campaign, while still also giving credit to the source. Along with that, as pointed out by my instructor: “This helps your reader have a lead for further research if they're interested in learning more about this topic.” She was right, not only does it do the work of giving an overview of the ad campaign. If the reader wants to look into it themselves, I have given them an effective lead. The other example from my work was when I defined “mushfake discourse” in

my Discourse Community Assignment: “In his article “Literacy, Discourse, and Linguistics: Introduction” Gee (1989) describes this type of interaction as “mush fake discourse” and defines it as “partial acquisition coupled with meta-knowledge and strategies to ‘make do’” (p.13)” (Logan, 2026a, p.12). This is something I’ve found I have a ton of fun playing with! In APA, you can introduce a quote by stating the last name of the author, then bringing in the quote. You just have to add (YEAR) after the name and a page number after the quote to make it clear you were bringing in a quote from that author. Not only that, but I was also able to fragment the quote I picked into the relevant parts of the definition, leaving out parts of the quote that were only relevant to the original text. Not only does it make it easier to understand what a “mushfake discourse” is; it also prevents the quote from taking over the essay, and I start quote bombing. I feel I have demonstrated that I meet the learning outcome “develop content to support claims in various rhetorical contexts” by showing my competency in introducing quotes and sources.

What is reflection

Now what’s the point of all this? Well, this portfolio is a tool of learning called “metacognition.” Metacognition is a reflection on past work and experiences. Looking back can help you understand what you missed, what you did well, and what you can improve. In “Reflections and Cover Letters” The authors describe how when professional basketball players practice, they are “going to go ‘meta’ or metacognitive as they improve to make more than a single lucky shot” (Hoermann-Elliot & Quesenbury, 2021). These players cannot rely on getting lucky; they must study their form and technique to know what they need to improve and how. Having a record of your work overtime shows patterns that help you better understand yourself, which helps you when working on similar ideas in the future. After my time in English 101, I feel confident in my

writing skills as I can critically think, I am open to diverse methods of writing and communication, and I can effectively find evidence and integrate sources to support my claims.

References

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